I Don't Always Teach the History of Economic Thought...But When I Do, I Prefer an NCAA-Style Tournament*

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Abstract

I describe an assignment for a history of economic thought (HET) course, "The Most Interesting Economist in History," modeled off of the NCAA Men's Basketball Tournament. Students vote in head-to-head matchups between economic writers by era for whom they find to be more "interesting" and explain their reasoning behind their votes. This assignment promotes active learning and is a more fun way of juggling complex themes and a slew of writers over a semester-long seminar.

JEL Classification: A10, A22, B00
Keywords: history of economic thought, assignments, economics education, active learning, tournament

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1 Introduction

A course in the history of economic thought (henceforth, HET) is an intensive semester for both student and instructor, as a slog through centuries of history of economic writings. Most programs feature such a course for upper-level economics majors, as requires students to wrestle with the weighty questions of our discipline, often via voluminous amounts of reading, writing, and discussion. It is thus logical to feature assignments such as papers (short and long) and in-class discussion (or discussion boards for online components). Aside from the motivated major (who often self-selects into the course), it can sometime be difficult to view the onslaught of writers and books as just "one damned thing after another," as Arnold Toynbee is said to have quippeed about history. A traditional course might cover (to varying degrees) north of 50 writers and their works.

In an attempt to alleviate such drudgery, I created a new type of assignment: an NCAA-style tournament to determine who is "The Most Interesting Economist in History"[1] It should also be noted that this was during the 2020— pandemic of COVID-19 when the NCAA had canceled the March 2020 basketball tournaments for the first time. The course, simply titled "The History of Economic Thought," is a required 400-level course for all economics majors, and traditionally a small seminar[2] focused on reading, writing, and discussion; taught at a small liberal arts college in the mid-Atlantic area of the United States. Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the course was taught online, but synchronously, with daily lectures delivered on Zoom and required weekly participation in online discussion boards.[3]

Economics instructors have long lamented the excessive[4] use of "chalk-and-talk" lecturing as the default mode of instruction and its associated consequences for student learning (Becker and Watts 1996, 2001; Becker 1997; Watts and Becker 2008). As a result, a number of researchers and educators have focused on the need for "active learning" where students engage with the content through a wide range of skill-building or participatory activities as opposed to passively receiving information (Freeman et al. 2014; Salemi 2002). Economic instructors have documented various active learning activities relevant for economics (Harmon and Lambrinos 2012), focusing on activities such as using the internet for research assigments (Simkins 1999), online assignments and discussion boards (Vachris 1999).

A history of economic thought course is a less common occasion at many colleges and universities today. Cohen and Emmett (2011) show that until the 1960s, HET courses were often a requirement at the university level, but became optional in the 1960s. Economists have long ruminated on the lack of attention paid by the profession to its history, both in research and in undergraduate instruction (see e.g. Stigler (1969); Boulding (1971); Blaug (2001); Kurz (2006).) Some economic practitioners view economic theory like mathematics, that the modern tools have incorporated all

[1] This is also deliberately patterned off of the popular Dos Equis beer commercials (and internet meme spinoffs) about "the most interesting man in the world."

[2] There were 11 students enrolled in the semester in which I pioneered this assignment

[3] I discuss more of this impact below.

[4] But perhaps necessary, by the sheer frequency fo revealed preference by economics instructors?

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of the wisdom of the ancients and discarded all of the dead-ends and settled all of the controversies of the past. In the extreme, some like Pigou notoriously find it a waste of time to study the "wrong theories of dead men"[5] If nothing else, we still find major works of writers like Smith, Ricardo, and Keynes in the "extended present" (Boulding 1971), as they remain the subject of active conversation and research.

Earnest debate about the usefulness of HET aside, teaching a such a course is a unique and intensive course. Cohen and Emmett (2011) outline the major challenges and provide a trove of suggested readings, objectives, and resources to design a HET course. Bethune (1992) provides a survey of 5 major textbooks for use in a HET class, albeit quite dated. Cardoso (1995) provides the results of a survey of HET instructors, attempting to crudely quantify the similarities and differences between how HET is taught, in terms of readings, themes, content, and requirements. A course in HET tends to be heavily focused on frequent reading, discussion, and writing, all surrounding major works and historical controversies of economics. This requires significant investment by both students and instructors. A number of instructors have shared innovative classroom setups or assignments in HET by using cluster discussions (Madden 2010), music (Horn and Horn 2013), role-playing (Oberhofer 1999), and twitter-based assignments (George 2019).

Below, I describe the logic of the "Most Interesting Economist in History" tournament assignment by first explaining the structure and influence of the NCAA March Madness tournament, on which this assignment is based. Next, I outline some of the necessary choices to be made in designing the assignment and calibrating it with the parameters of a HET course. I then describe what I see as the main benefits of the assignments, and conclude. The actual assignment prompt and samples used in my course are provided as Appendix A and Appendix B, respectively.

2 Structure and Logic of the Assignment

2.1 The Analogy: NCAA Tournament

The main inspiration for this assignment comes from the National Collegiate Athletics Association (NCAA) Division I Men's Basketball Tournament, known colloquially as "March Madness," due to the tournament of 68 Division I collegiate basketball teams competing in March for the national championship.[6] March Madness is one of the most lucrative sports and television events — and constitutes the majority of NCAA's annual revenues, even though only about 3% of NCAA athletes compete in the tournament (Tracy 2016). Its current 8-year extended contract with CBS Sports and Turner (owner of the cable channel TBS) to broadcast games through 2032, is worth $8.8 billion (Tracy 2016).[7] The 2018 tournament was estimated to have generated $1.32 billion in televeision ad revenue alone, reaching

[5] Recounted in Robbins (1998, 297) and alluded to in Boulding (1971)). See Dimand, Dimand, and Forget (2000) for the role of exceptional *women* in the history of economics.

[6] Four games are held among 8 teams in the "first four" games that determine the 16th seed in each of the four divisions, narrowing the field down to the familiar 64-team tournament bracket.

[7] Its most recent contract was for 14 years, from 2010—2024, valued at $10.8 billion, or about $770 million per year.

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about 100 million people in 180 countries (Ozanian 2019). While it draws less revenue than the NFL postseason ($1.68 billion), it surpasses the NBA playoffs ($970 million), MLB playoffs ($468 million), and NCAA Division 1 college football bowl games ($382 million) in terms of ad revenue (Ozanian 2019).

The most prominent feature of March Madness is the "bracket" tracking the progress of each time in each round of the tournament. Millions of fans fill out their own brackets each year to predict the champion, comparing with friends and coworkers, and numerous officially-sponsored contests offer prizes for the most accurate brackets. Sports journalists also frequently compare rank bracket predictions on broadcast TV and print articles as the tournament progresses. Indeed, the "science" of predicting brackets has been affectionately dubbed "bracketology," largely due to ESPN basketball analyst Joe Lunardi (Branch 2006). The NCAA describes the tournament:

> "Those 64 teams are split into four regions of 16 teams each, with each team being ranked 1 through 16. That ranking is the team's seed.
>
> In order to reward better teams, first-round matchups are determined by pitting the top team in the region against the bottom team (No. 1 vs. No. 16). Then the next highest vs. the next lowest (No. 2 vs. No. 15), and so on. In theory, this means that the 1 seeds have the easiest opening matchup to win in the bracket." NCAA (2020)

To organize the tournament, each of the 64 teams are initially placed in one of four "divisions" (North, South, East, and West) to play single-elimination head-to-head matchups through the round of 32, the round of 16 "the Sweet Sixteen," the round of 8 "the Elite Eight," the round of 4 "the Final Four," and the championship game between the 2 surviving teams. See figure 1 for the official NCAA (empty) bracket for the 2020 season.

2.2 The Assignment

To fit the parameters of the assignment to the broad schedule and pace of the course, I selected 8 writers from each division, or 32 writers in total. This maintains an even number, divisible by four, to follow the NCAA style tournament. In each division, there will be 7 head to head matchups—4 in the first round, 2 in the second round, 1 in the final round—and with each division champion in the final four, three additional head-to-head matchups through the championship. This brings the total number of matchups (and votes required by the students) to 31 over the course of the semester.

I divided the course up into four key "eras" that would ultimately coincide with the four divisions of the tournament bracket: the Pre-Classical, the Classical, the Neoclassical, and the Modern. Each era approximately covers one quarter of the semester in sequence. Upon finishing the course material (readings, lectures, and discussions) for each "era," the division's initial bracket is released on a discussion board thread, and students are instructed to begin voting in

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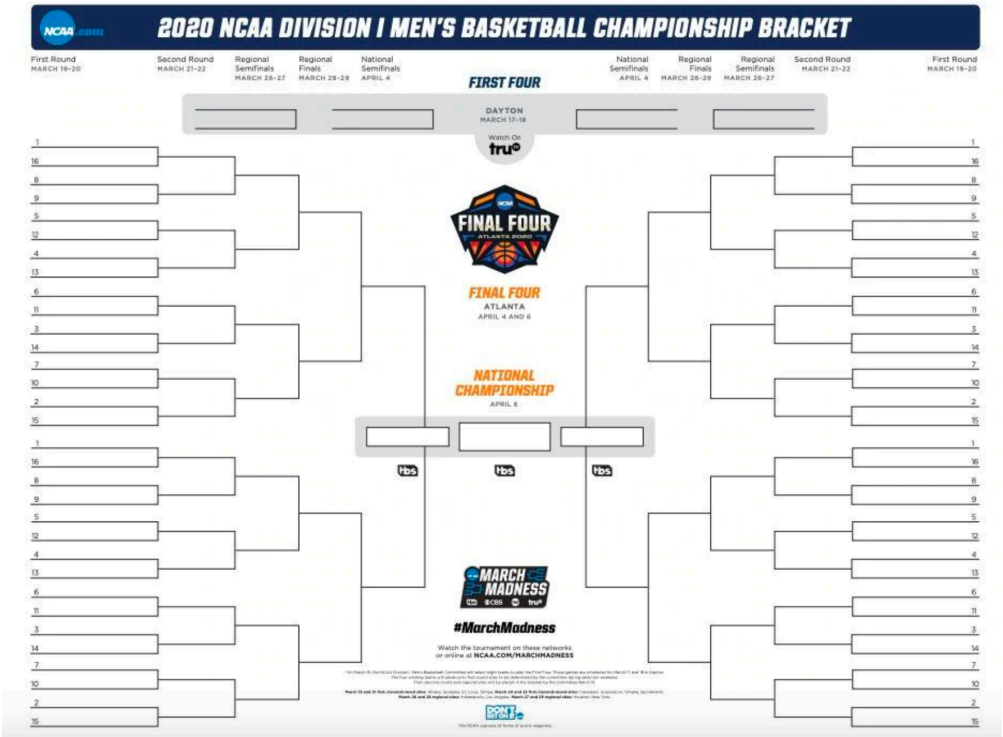

Figure 1: Sample NCAA Basketball Bracket for 2020 Season

the first round. With 8 writers chosen for an "era"[8], this yields 4 head-to-head matchups, so students are required in the first round to provide four votes. When all students have voted, the winners of each matchup proceed to the second round of 2 head-to-head matchups, votes are solicited again, and the winners proceed to the final round of a single head-to-head matchup, selecting the winner of a division. To minimize overlap and the requirement of students to juggle many names (some of which they have not heard for weeks), we proceed with only a single division/era at a time. In the final weeks of the course, when all four winners of each division have been selected, they (the "Final Four") proceed to 2 head-to-head matchups, and the winners of those proceed to the final matchup, to become "The Most Interesting Economist in History." See Appendix B for an example bracket used in my course.

As the tournament is entitled "The Most Interesting Economist in History," I ask my students in each head-to-head matchup to:

> "Vote for whomever you think is more"interesting." You can define this however you like: creative, original, weird, memorable, controversial, influential...it's up to you!"

This criterion yields a lot of interesting votes and discussions, perhaps more than strictly requiring students to vote on a more "objective" criterion like influence or originality, if that were possible.

[8]See the next section for discussion about selecting and seeding writers.

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To further encourage learning and critical thinking, I occasionally require students to *explain* their votes publicly in a few sentences (per head-to-head matchup) that are graded. This forces them to think a bit more rigorously and defend their thoughts, rather than voting uninformed or haphazardly simply to complete a required assignment. There is a tradeoff, however, between having students grapple with their thoughts, and simply creating too much "busy-work" in writing more explanations. Again, with 32 writers, this produces 31 head-to-head matchups over the semester. Requiring (and grading) 31 paragraphs worth of explanations from students over the semester could be the length of a term paper per student. The optimum tradeoff, in my opinion, is to alert students at the beginning of the semester that for any round, of any division, I *might* ask students to explain their votes publicly, or I might not. In practice, I "randomly" required only 1 round worth of explanations per division, often in earlier rounds (where there are more names to juggle), but this provides ample room for the instructor's discretion. See Appendix A for the prompt, and the next section for more discussion of grading, and see Appendix B for examples of student explanations of their votes, both insightful and amusing.

I highly suggest the votes and explanations for the votes are held publicly — either in person, or posted on an online discussion board for all students to see. This allows students to see how their classmates rank the writers and the varied reasons . As a fun side benefit, it also allows classmates to "campaign" or "lobby" their classmates to vote for a particular writer they feel strongly about.

I suggest using a learning management system's discussion board feature to post the tournament rounds as threads, where students can post their vote (and explanations, as occasionally required) as a reply in the thread. This not only makes votes public (which has important benefits, as described in the next section), but also enables the instructor to track who voted and see who has not yet voted, both for grading purposes and for whipping votes to proceed to the next round in a timely fashion.[9]

2.3 Arranging the Competitors

Just as it is unavoidable in a single semester course in the History of Economic Thought that not all writers can be read or discussed, it is equally unavoidable that not all writers can be a part of the tournament.[10] The writers included in the tournament will depend upon the textbooks used, the scope of content that the course covers,[11] and various other writers that students discuss in or out of class. My course primarily utilized Medema and Samuels (2013) for primary sources and Landreth and Colander (2002) for helpful commentary, to serve as the textbooks for

[9] I learned this the hard way. If holding votes not as a thread on a discussion forum, such as on a survey-collection site like Surveymonkey or Google Forms, be sure to require students to submit their names with their votes to track who has voted and who has not!

[10] A key portion of the assignment is to describe several writers—whether discussed in the course or not—that students wish had featured in the tournment. This is discussed below.

[11] Or, more accurately, how far in time the instructor is able to cover as the semester wraps up. The writings of John Maynard Keynes seems to be a common endpoint for most courses to target.

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the course.[12]

In principle, a bracket can be designed to accommodate any number of thinkers and divisions (or one can forgo the entire concept of "divisions," featuring a single tournament across all "eras" of history). Online tools such as BracketHQ permit all permutations of brackets of at least 4 "teams" (here: individual thinkers) up to 32 (in the free version). At the very least, I strongly suggest keeping with brackets containing a number of teams that are powers of 2 (2,4,8,16,32), to create consistent "head-to-head" matchups between two writers without privileging any particular writer in the bracket.

Additionally, this requires a bit of work on the instructor's part in arranging the first-round matchups. As in the real NCAA tournament, a common strategy is to establish "seeds" for the thinkers in such a way that prevents two higher-seeds from being matched up in early rounds. For example, it is a poor strategy to allow two intellectual heavyweights such as Adam Smith and David Ricardo to be matched up for a vote right away, better to match both Smith and Ricardo each with a lesser-known writer such as Robert Torrens or Henry Thornton in the initial round.

As I emphasize to my students, these four divisions are largely fictions created the benefit of an orderly tournament, rather than a neat historical sequence of clearly-defined stages. The final "stage" in particular—the "Modern Era"—covers a hodgepodge of orthodox and heterodox themes and developments, amalgamating Keynes' *General Theory*, Samuelson's formalist methods, the socialist calculation debate, and Veblen's critiques. Furthermore, as this is the era that is covered last, during the "crunch time" of the final weeks of the semester, much of the mid-20th century developments that a consensus of economists would consider important are necessarily cut for time.

Table 1 lists the brackets (with seeds) that I used, with the caveat that I chose the particular seeds using the online BracketHQ tool[13] to allocate matchups to solve the problem mentioned above, *not* because I subjectively believe these are the proper "rankings" of the thinkers. It is more for illustration of keeping heavyweights apart than the author's personal opinion. Table 2 suggests other authors applicable to each era except for the modern era[14]

[12] For full disclosure, I also suggested Blaug (1996) as an advanced source for interested students, and also utilized Robbins (1998) to prep my own lectures.

[13] https://brackethq.com

[14] The "Modern Era" is too close to contemporary work in economics such that becomes dependent on the instructor's own attitudes and preferences about modern economics, unlike prior "eras." Additionally, my "Modern Era" is an amalgamation of various heterodox and orthodox traditions.

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Table 1 - Writers used for tournament, by division and seed

Seed	Pre-Classical	Classical	Neoclassical	Modern
1.	Aristotle	Adam Smith	Alfred Marshall	John Maynard Keynes
2.	A.R.J. Turgot	David Ricardo	William S Jevons	Paul Samuelson
3.	Thomas Aquinas	Karl Marx	Carl Menger	Milton Friedman
4.	Richard Cantillon	Thomas Malthus	Eugen von Bohm-Bawerk	F.A. Hayek
5.	William Petty	David Hume	Irving Fisher	Thorstein Veblen
6.	Francois Quesnay	John Stuart Mill	Leon Walras	John Hicks
7.	John Locke	Henry Thornton	Vilfredo Pareto	Ludwig von Mises
8.	Bernard Mandeville	Jean-Baptiste Say	John Bates Clark	Oskar Lange

Table 2 - Some suggested other writers

Pre-Classical Era	Classical Era	Neoclassical Era
Plato	Robert Torrens	Francis Ysidro Edgeworth
Guan Zhong	Edward West	Friedrich von Wieser
Xenophon	Nassau Senior	Frank Knight
Hesiod	Jeremy Bentham	Knut Wicksell
Ibn Khaldun	Friedrich List	Wesley Clair Mitchell
Thomas Mun	Gustav von Schmoller	John R Commons
Thomas Hobbes	A.A. Cournot	Joan Robinson
David Hume	J.H. Von Thunen	Lionel Robbins
	H.H. Gossen	
	Jules Dupuit	

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One natural issue that tournament such as this raises, consistent with the history of economic thought (at least how it is commonly taught and written about) more broadly, is the lack of representation of women and people of color. Some textbooks do pay some attention to non-Western economic thought, and include several female writers. However, in a tournament such as this, where it is difficult enough to select 8 among the white male writers of each era that had a lasting impact, it may further highlight the under-representation problem. As our discipline continues to grapple with this problem, both about the history of our field, along with its current demographics and professional culture today, I can only encourage instructors to comment about this and make it a topic of discussion for students.[15] Clever or politically-active students are already likely to point out this problem upon some reflection about which writers were covered over the course of the semester.

Once the tournament has been completed, one final graded post that I require of students is for them to each provide several writers—whether discussed in the course or not—that students wish had featured in the tournament, but did not, and why. With this venue, some students pointed out the lack of women and people of color, and suggested several that they had read about in other courses, such as Elinor Ostrom, Mary Paley Marshall, Joan Robinson, and others. See Appendix B for some example comments.

2.3.1 Grading

As a HET course often features participation or discussion as a graded component of the course, this assignment may easily be graded along similar lines, as a special required case of participation/discussion grade. Whether the course (or at least, the discussion component) is online or in-person, the tournament assignment can be assessed and graded similarly, or submitted and graded as would a small writing assignment — by submission on a learning management system, by email, or in-person on paper.

I graded my assignments as I state in the syllabus and the discussion board threads that:

> Your grade for each round of votes that requires explanations will be out of 5 points, and you will be graded on your reasoning for your votes. Your average grade for your explanations across all of the rounds (out of 100%) will constitute 10% of your final course grade.

3 Benefits of the Assignment

This assignment not only helps students both recall a variety of economic writers and their major contributions, but also requires students to make subjective comparisons of writers and demonstrate their reasoning. This requires

[15] Again, see Dimand, Dimand, and Forget (2000) as well as Marginal Revolution University's Women in Economics video series for helpful material highlighting female contributions to economics.

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students to understand and internalize the key ideas, contributions, and influence that each writer had (even if students may not fully understand how each theory may work), and exercise their own judgment in making comparisons between authors based on various metrics of influence.

I view this assignment as a complement, not a substitute, to other more writing-focused assignments (short and long). A HET course might have written exams, but often ones that are essay-based and theme-focused, rather than questions that require rote memorization of names, sequence, and contribution of various writers. This assignment certainly provides a better way for students to remember a long list of names of economic writers and their contributions by making relative comparisons on various margins of interest, rather than memorization for its own sake (or for the sake of performing well on an exam).

Finally, of course, this assignment provides a lot of enjoyment both to student and instructor to see how the matchups turn out and what reasons students provide for their votes.

A The Assignment

A.1 Assignment Brief

Since we all missed out on the NCAA Basketball Tournament last spring, I have set up a tournament for "the most interesting economist in history." Each era of economic thought (Pre-Classical, Classical, Neoclassical, and Modern) will have its own "division," in which we will vote for the champion of each era (out of up to 8 thinkers), who will then go head to head against the champions of other divisions for the title.

Once we complete an era, we will hold the votes in head-to-head matchups between economists. Your assignment is to write up a short explanation behind your vote (1-3 sentences) between each pair. This will allow you to remember and place each thinker in the context of the history of economic thought.

Your grade for each round of votes that requires explanations will be out of 5 points, and you will be graded on your reasoning for your votes. Your average grade for your explanations across all of the rounds (out of 100%) will constitute 10% of your final course grade.

A.2 Discussion Board thread for each Division

[Note, the following is meant to be a thread on a discussion forum. Each era features a forum with a thread for each round of the tournament that students will post replies in, as well as a thread allowing students to make predictions before the first round completes. As it can be re-posted with slight variations for each round/division,

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I indicate the modifications in brackets.]

The bracket for the **[Era]** division is set! Naturally, to balance the bracket, I had to leave out several thinkers that we discussed, or move some from this era into other eras/divisions. This will be inevitable.

Here is the bracket if you want to fill out your own for predictions (post below) for bonus points, true NCAA style: **[link to brackethq website]**

We will now begin first round head-to-head voting. Please vote by replying in the thread below.

Vote for whomever you think is more "interesting." You can define this however you like: creative, original, weird, memorable, controversial, influential...it's up to you!

For this round, you **[do not/need to]** post your explanations.

To avoid swaying the outcome, I will not be voting. There are 11 of us, so we should not need any tie-breakers (in that possibility, I would vote!). Please vote ASAP, once we get 11 votes in, we will proceed to the next round and I will update you.

Your grade for each round of votes that requires explanations will be out of 5 points, and you will be graded on your reasoning for your votes. Your average grade for your explanations across all of the rounds (out of 100%) will constitute 10% of your final course grade.

Thanks, and have fun!

A.3 Who'd We Leave Out? [Final Discussion Board Thread at end of Tournament]

One necessary limitation of this tournament is that I have to limit the "contestants" to 8 per division. Even though we can only focus on so many economists in this course (and are leaving out lots of interesting writers), I still have to limit the tournament to a small subset of even that. There were a good number of writers we mentioned, read, or discussed, but did not make it into the tournament.

I would like each of you, as part of your grade for the tournament, to list at least 2 (up to you if you want to do more) writers that did not make the tournament that you found "interesting" (again, defined however you want!) that we could/should have included in the tournament, with your explanation of why you found them interesting. I will also open this up to interesting writers that we did not get to talk about in class that you may have otherwise heard of!

As a reminder, here is the full bracket (we started with): **[See Appendix A.3]**

If you can believe it, we've covered 32 different writers in the tournament!

Please post below with your explanations.

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A.4 Brackets

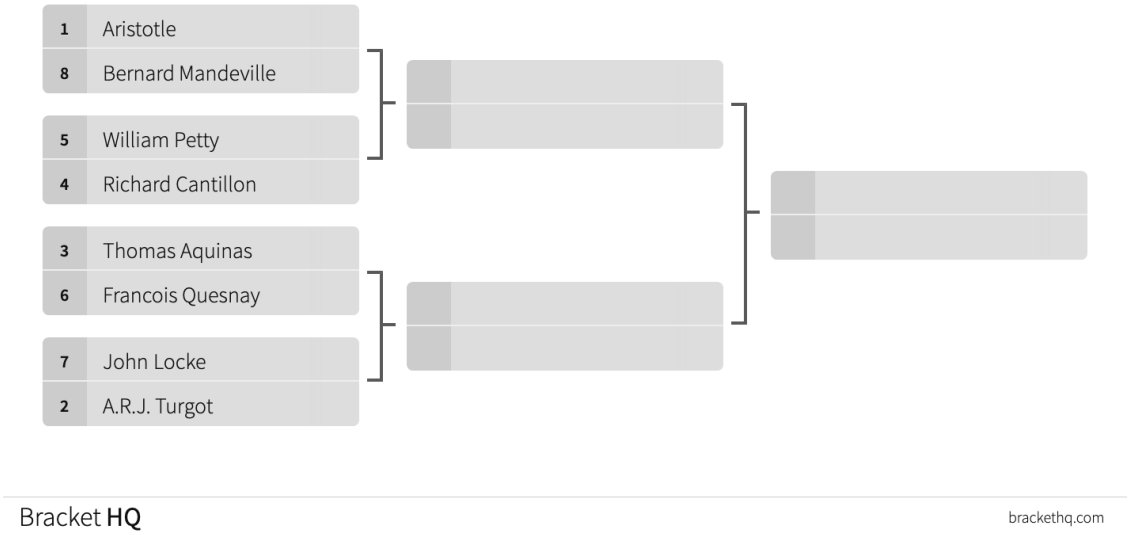

Figure 2: Empty Pre-Classical Division Bracket

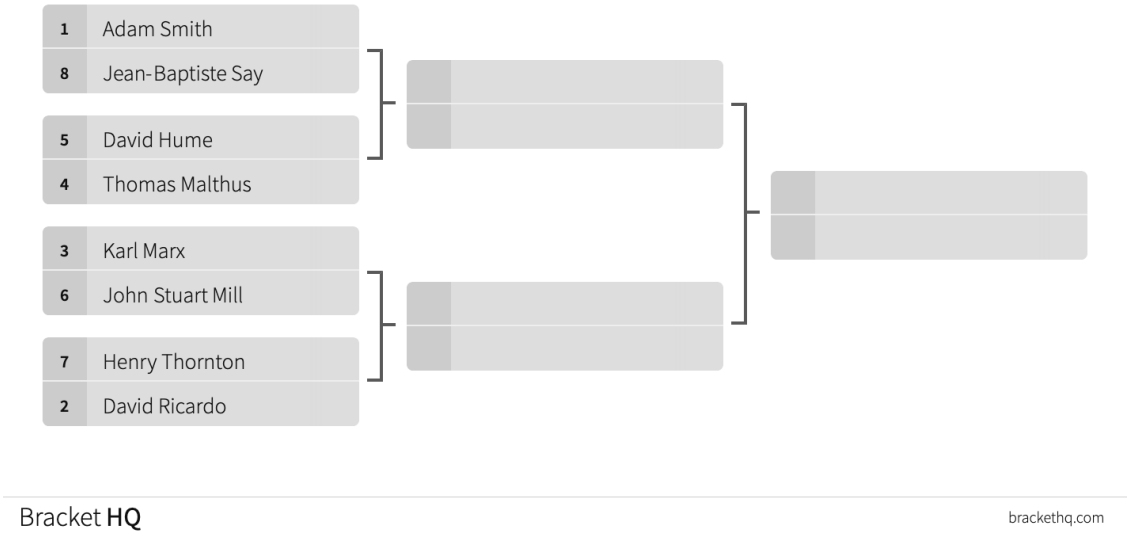

Figure 3: Empty Classical Division Bracket

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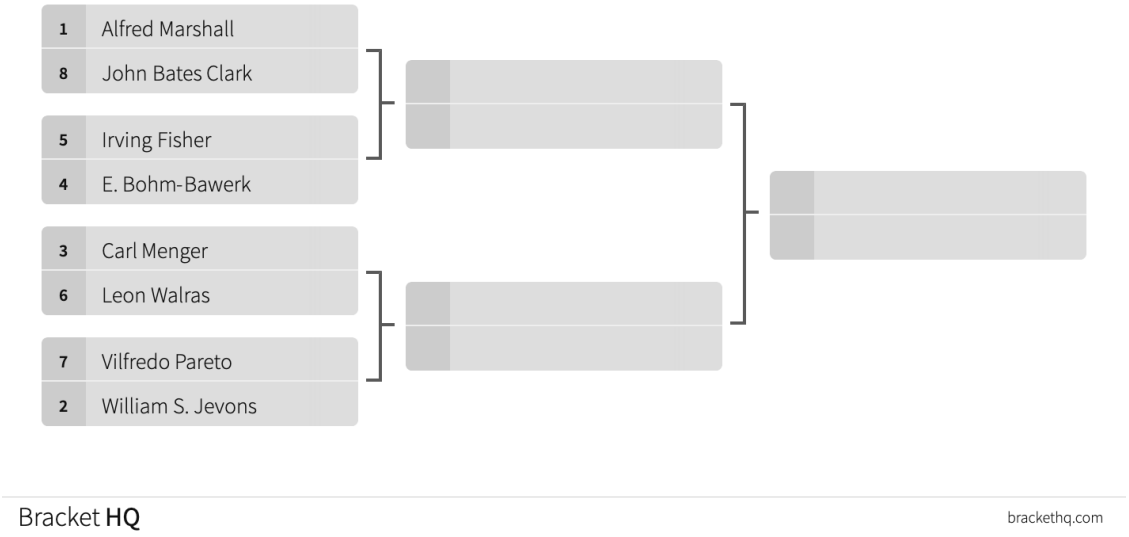

Figure 4: Empty Neoclassical Division Bracket

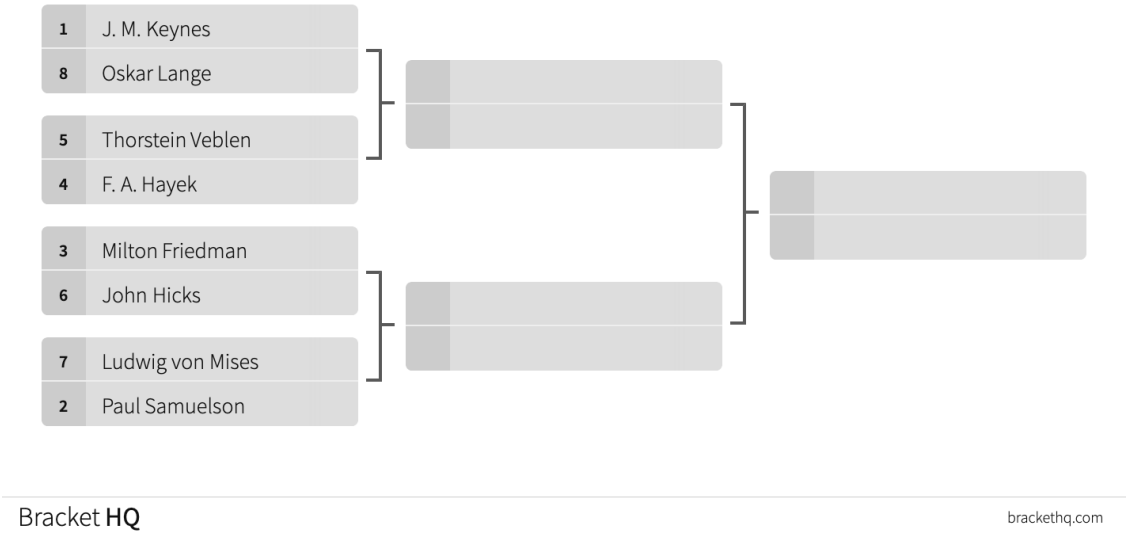

Figure 5: Empty Modern Division Bracket

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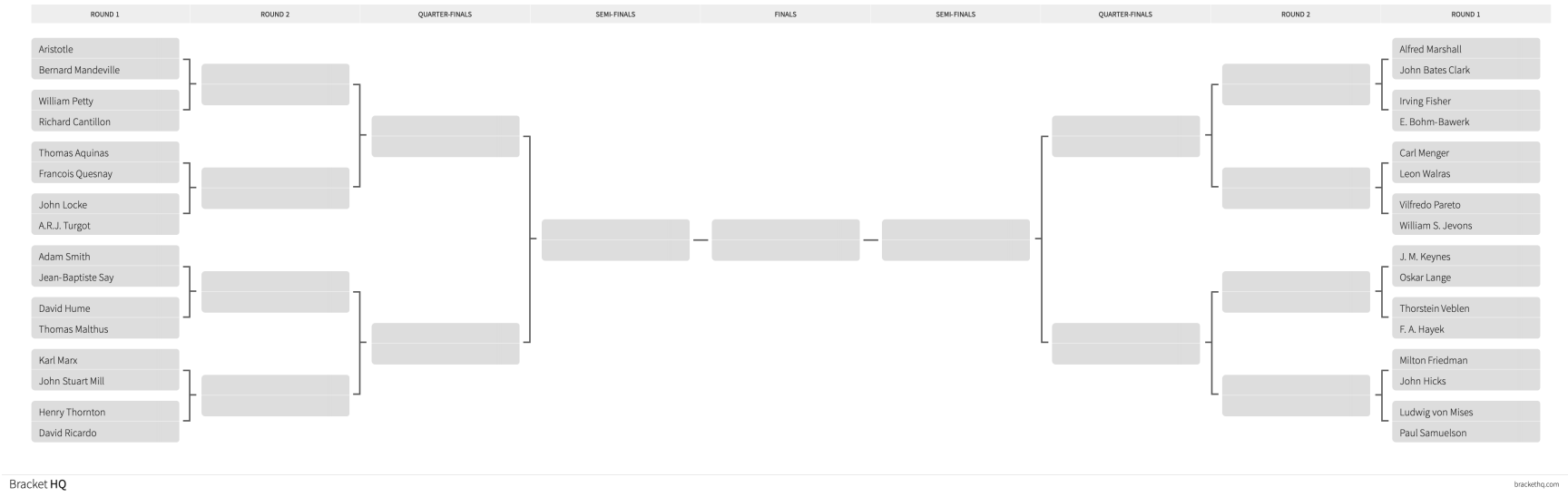

Figure 6: Empty Full Bracket

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B Selected Vote Explanations

"I choose [Richard] Cantillon [vs. Bernard Mandeville] because his astuteness in analyzing, predicting, and profiting from the Mississippi company's financial catastrophe has helped us learn about speculation. Of course, he is a significant influence on modern economics (Cantillon effects). Finally, I think he showed us a clear example that economics is not about morality."

"For the second [matchup of John Locke vs. A.R.J. Turgot], it has to be John Locke. He played such an integral role in the ideals we hold as a nation, that it's hard not to choose him. And with quotes like"Education begins the gentleman, but reading, good company and reflection must finish him" and "The only fence against the world is a thorough knowledge of it" he's just too good!"

"I chose [Richard] Cantillon [vs. Bernard Mandeville] for my first choice because I like how he was an empirical thinker. He used a lot of data and statistics for his Essay on the nature of commerce. I also think it's interesting that his beliefs are considered to be aligned with mixture the mercantilists and the physiocrats."

"My first vote goes to [Bernard] Mandeville [vs. Richard Cantillon]. I think that his questioning of human morals and the proposal that humans are always self-interested and brutal towards others is very controversial, yet arguably true. Are we only motivated by what benefits us?"

"While I believe Mandeville's Fable of the Bees is one of the more interesting pieces of economic literature we've read so far this semester (it's why I voted for him in the first round), I believe the mystery behind Cantillon's life and beliefs makes his writing far more interesting; he's like an economic dark horse. I feel the fact that Cantillon contributed so much to the early field of economics and yet so little is known about him makes him interesting."

"Jean Baptiste Say inadvertently sparked one of the biggest debates in economic history, so I think he's more interesting than Adam Smith (who isn't nearly as interesting by nature of being the classic economist)."

"John Stuart Mill is also a super influential feminist who listened to the women in his life and genuinely wanted to make their lives better, and I wrote my first paper on him so I'm partial [over Karl Marx]"

"Thomas Malthus over David Hume because the Malthusian Population Doctrine is so interesting. I don't think it was completely accurate, and Malthus didn't really foresee how the Industrial Revolution would change everything eventually, but it is an interesting essay in the first edition, and the following editions were a heroic effort at empiricism and econometrics given the tools and information available at the

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time. I think Hume is a brilliant philosopher, but if I'm to judge him based on his economic contributions I think Malthus was more interesting personally, especially when you take into account his contrarian take on the corn laws."

"John Bates Clark [vs. Alfred Marshall]–he's the first big name in US economics, and for economists who work in the US, the medal awarded in his name is considered a bigger deal than the Nobel prize in economics (which is technically a memorial prize, but you know what I mean). I am also voting for him in part because I've done a lot of research into Alfred Marshall, and he was kinda the worst/is making my second short paper a pain. Why would someone who encouraged the woman he ended up marrying, and advocated for her having a position as a lecturer at every university he worked, decide (ten years later) that women should not be able to get degrees? She was a professor of political economy (the same thing he taught men) for women for thirty years...It's complicated."

"Carl Menger–he was probably my favorite neoclassicist to learn about, and he also had the best beard."

"My fourth choice is Vilfredo Pareto. While his concept of"Pareto improvements" and equilibrium are very interesting and have many different applications in the field, it's his controversial views on eugenics that make him most interesting to me. Not that I agree with any of his views [towards Italian fascism late in his life] (they are abhorrent), I just find it fascinating that I've read so much of Pareto in several economics classes and had no idea that he held beliefs such as this."

"While [Oskar] Lange's work on the concept of market socialism was influential for several socialistic economies in Eastern Europe, I have to vote for [John Maynard] Keynes as his General Theory is far more interesting. The idea that an economist can write a badly written and difficult to understand thesis and still be considered one of the most influential macroeconomists in history is astounding to me. I would vote for him for the simple fact that people often quote him without even reading him, that's influence."

"This is definitely the hardest decision on the ballot so far. [Paul] Samuelson's work to help establish economics as a modern mathematical science is monumental. I've been fascinated and interested in the analytical side of economics ever since I took Econometrics, so his work helped me find that passion. [Ludwig von] Mises, on the other hand, has forced me to change my mind on several aspects of socialism which I used to (and still somewhat do) staunchly defend. If I'm forced to make a choice, I think I'd have to go with Mises as I still read him for different perspectives while I don't read Samuelson nearly as much."

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B.1 On Who We Left Out

"I think Mary Paley Marshall would have been an interesting economist to study. I believe we briefly talked about her in class. She was the wife of Alfred Marshall, and helped to write their book"The Economics of Industry." But beyond that, Mary was also one of the first five women to ever been accepted to study economics at the Cambridge University. She also became the first ever female economics lecturer at the university. Those are pretty big accomplishments, I'd say!"

"I think that Thomas Mun would be a good addition to the Pre-Classical division. He really set the stage for the mercantilists of the era and influenced the idea of having a balance of trade greatly. I also think he was very hypocritical, which is pretty interesting. I say this because he was a wealthy merchant and the director of the East India Company, which outsourced resources from India resulting in an outflow of money. This contradicted the mercantilist ideals of importing as little as possible in order to maintain a positive balance of trade. It was very controversial at the time for him to be doing this."

"While I don't think he was as influential as many of the other economists of the Classical Era, I think Henry George's theory of Georgism is very interesting when considered in relation to the other arguments over property rights during the time. Before George's"competitive common ownership" concept, the debate over private or communal property was a zero-sum game in which all aspects of property had to be in control entirely by the State or private individuals. Giving the most unproductive but still lucrative aspect of property over to the State so that they can use the rents to generate social welfare was clever. It supported competition by not interfering with capitalists and workers allowed for the State to release the tax pressure on poorer individuals, potentially helping to ameliorate Western society's problem with wealth distribution. George's work would even go on to influence Walras's theory of 'synthetic socialism,' at least in part."

"The other economist I'd really like to highlight is Joan Robinson, arguably one of the most influential female economists of the 20th century and of Post-Keynesian economics. Much of Robinson's most influential work came from her book *The Economics of Imperfect Competition*, where she first coined the term"monopsony", a concept now discussed thoroughly in Industrial Organization. I find Robinson interesting not only for her influence on economics in the NeoClassical Era, but because much of her work was focused on methods in which to uplift the underdeveloped and developing world."

"I think Elinor Ostrom would have been a nice addition to the list, both as an interesting New Institutionalist and the first (and only, until 2019) woman to win the Nobel prize in economics. She did a lot of research into problems with"the tragedy of the commons" and countered the idea of the helpless

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citizen, especially with her work "Governing the Commons" which talks about collective action. One of my favorite quotes of hers is 'There is no reason to believe that bureaucrats and politicians, no matter how well meaning, are better at solving problems than the people on the spot, who have the strongest incentive to get the solution right.'"

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